THE RAMBAM'S EIGHT CHAPTERS - SHEMONAH PERAKIM

Healing a Bad Trait by Going to the Other Extreme

The Rambam's Eight Chapters, Chapter 4, Part 1

Sefer: Shemonah Perakim (the Eight Chapters) by the Rambam **Chapter:** Chapter 4, first half **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Tuesday-night series on the Shemonah Perakim, Tuesday 27 February 2024

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

From the illness to the cure

The Rabbi called Chapter 4 perhaps the most important of the eight: "We've talked about the illnesses, now we talk about the cure."

He reviewed the story so far. Chapter 1: one soul with five faculties. Chapter 2: the Torah speaks to faculty 4, our desires, which faculty 2, the senses, carries out. A thief who does not steal only for fear of the police is still a thief in his nefesh. Chapter 3: the soul can be ill like the body, and we need a hakham as a doctor. The illnesses are the two extremes, too little of something or too much. The worst case is not knowing you are ill. Chapter 4 is long, so it would take two weeks.

The middle path

The Rambam opens: good deeds are those balanced between two extremes, both of which are bad. One extreme is **excess** and the other is **deficiency**.

The Rabbi asked why the Rambam speaks of good deeds and then of good virtues. A participant answered: deeds are faculty 2 and virtues are faculty 4. The virtue is the balanced trait in the soul, and it produces balanced actions.

The first example is **restraint** (*zehirut*), the middle between indulgence, pursuing every pleasure, and insensibility, enjoying nothing at all. Having no desire for anything is also a defect. "I desire, but I desire with restraint. That's the middle path."

At this stage the Rambam treats both extremes as equally bad. Do not think excess is better than deficiency: someone who is "too kind" is as far off as someone who is unkind. The Rambam will add a caveat to this.

The list of traits

The Rambam goes through many traits and admits that some have no exact name in his language. The Rabbi said the same is true in English, so the idea matters more than the exact

word. He asked the class to keep track of which side is the excess and which is the deficiency, because it will matter later.

- **Generosity** is between miserliness and extravagance.
- **Courage** is between recklessness and cowardice. If you cannot swim and jump into the sea to save someone, people will call you a hero; the Rambam would call it recklessness. But a strong swimmer who will not help because of a small risk is a coward.
- **Dignity** is between self-importance and not caring about yourself at all.
- **Humility** is between arrogance and self-abasement. The person who always says "I'm not good enough" is not humble. "Humility is knowing who you are, your place, but not being arrogant about it."
- **Contentment** is between the love of more and more and a laziness that will not provide even a roof or clothes.
- **Good-heartedness** is between indifference, not helping even when it costs you nothing, and helping others at great loss to yourself.
- **Patience** is between anger and not feeling an insult at all. The Rabbi noted that one could argue either side is the excess here.
- **Modesty** (*boshet panim*) is between brazenness and excessive shyness. Avot says "the bashful one does not learn" and also that *boshet panim* leads to Gan Eden. The two are not the same: the *bayshan* is too shy to ask, while *boshet panim* is the healthy middle.

The Rambam ends the list: once the principle is clear, we need not worry about the names.

The middle path in Tanakh and Hazal

The Rabbi said the golden mean is clearly Aristotle's, but Tanakh and Hazal point to it too: - A verse in Mishlei about weighing the path of your feet, which Ibn Ezra reads as weighing your way as on a scale. "This whole spiritual process is a balancing game." - Kohelet: "Do not be overly righteous, and do not be overly wise." Even religious extremes are not good. - Hazal compare the study of the Divine Chariot to two paths, one of fire and one of snow. Veer into either and you die; walk in the middle. - The Gemara says a talmid hakham needs an eighth of an eighth of pride. One with too much is censured, and so is one with none. A hakham sometimes has to stand up for the honour of the Torah he represents.

Mistaken praise

People often praise the extremes. They admire the one who keeps putting himself in danger and comes out unscathed, though he was only lucky. They call the one who takes every insult "patient", but that is self-abasement. They call a lazy person "content" and the one who never enjoys anything "holy". The Rabbi recalled people saying of someone that he ate without tasting the food, and some see that as a high level. The Rambam would call it wrong. And they praise someone who throws his money around, or whose kindness comes at the expense of his own family. Only the balanced person deserves praise.

How character is formed

Now the key question: how do we actually change? The Rambam says virtues and vices settle in the soul only by **repeating the actions** that come from them, many times over a long period, until they become habits.

So everything starts in faculty 4, but the way to change faculty 4 is through faculty 2, through action. The influence runs both ways. The Rabbi gave an example from psychology: a person who is low who smiles, dances and laughs anyway, again and again, can lift his mood over time.

The Rambam adds that no one is born good or bad (Chapter 8 will develop this). We pick up habits from childhood, from parents, family, community and society. A person lucky enough to grow up in a balanced home will be balanced. Most of us, the Rabbi suggested, grew up somewhere that leaned one way or the other.

The cure: bend it back

The Rambam takes his method from medicine. When the body goes out of balance, we push it the other way until it returns. The Rabbi's example: after hours hunched over a computer, a physiotherapist has you hold an unusually straight posture for a few weeks. Once the pain is gone, you go back to a normal posture. Hold the opposite too long and you have a new problem.

The same with character. A miser is not told "be like that generous man." He is told to be extravagant: spend on things even wealthy people do not buy. It will be very hard at first. "Barely buys a loaf of bread for himself, and now has to go to Selfridges." He keeps at it until the miserliness is gone and he is close to becoming extravagant. Then we say stop, and now be balanced: spend when you need to and look after yourself.

How long? It depends how ill you are. If the healthy point is 50 and you are at 30, a short time at the other side may be enough. If you are at 5, you may need to stay at the other extreme for a long time. One sign is when you start to enjoy the new extreme: then it is time to come back.

This is why, the Rabbi said, Torah tradition values having a mentor or a true friend. We cannot always see ourselves. Ask: am I too much this, too little that? Work on it for a month, then check again.

A question for next week

He ended with a question. If you cannot be at 50, would you rather be at 75 or 25? His first example, arrogance against self-abasement, did not work, as a participant pointed out, because Hazal warn specially against anger and pride. So he used kindness: too kind (75) or unkind (25)? After some discussion, one participant gave the answer he was looking for: 75 "can be managed." Both are equally defective, but it is far easier to come down from 75 to 50 than to climb from 25 to 50. That is why the hasidim would lean slightly towards 55 rather than drop to 45. "To be continued."

Summary

- Good deeds and good traits lie in the middle between excess and deficiency, and both extremes are illnesses of the soul.
- People often praise the extremes, such as recklessness as bravery or self-abasement as patience, but only the middle deserves praise.
- Traits are formed by repeated actions, so we change faculty 4 by working through faculty 2.
- The cure is to go to the opposite extreme for a time, then return to the middle, ideally with a mentor or friend to help us see ourselves.
- Both extremes are equally bad, but one is easier to return from, which sets up the Rambam's idea of the hasid.

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